MED0130 · INDUSTRIAL DESIGN BASICS

Product Analysis

Product: XAHAU Scholarship Backpack

Student: Jordan Thomas Brodie , 243483



THESIS

At first look this bag looks expensive and sophisticated. But in to more analysis of the bag, I have found it ti be made with cheaper fabrics and textiles. The bag is built for appearance more than to last for a long time. It is a product where the aesthetics doesn’t match the quality, and this is the design story.

1. Context Analysis

Socio-Cultural Context

Nowadays, most students and professionals carry backpacks around with them. Often moving from point A to point B in public spaces where theft may take place, there is a need for bags that can hide tech to protect it from being stolen.



Backpacks are a part of student life. In general, students are used to carrying them everywhere, and with the rise of the laptop it has become important to incorporate a laptop compartment, a port to charge your phone portably, and the ability to listen to music.

Blockchains are all the rage right now in tech and IT. Companies like Xahau and the InFTF foundation are trying to attract serious, talented people to be part of it. Giving a scholarship recipient something useful, like a bag such as this, is a way to encourage students to invest time and energy to work and learn about blockchain, while at the same time showing more support and encouragement to the students.

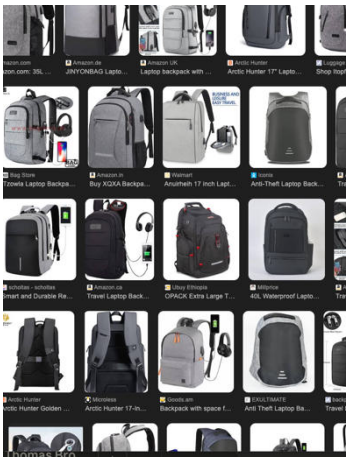
Organisational Context

X Xahau and the InFTF foundation are a blockchain and crypto company; they don't manufacture physical products for the commercial market. At first, I thought that this product was a Xahau bag because I didn't realize what Xahau is. In my search, I realized that Xahau is a blockchain company, which makes sense because the essay I had to write for the InFTF scholarship was about blockchains. So I realized that they must have purchased this product from a wholesaler or another manufacturer and put their logo on it. I could not find a tag or any revelation of which manufacturer they bought it from — there were no traces on the bag.

When I first got the bag, I felt very honored. It was nice to receive something useful when I won this scholarship. In fact, I needed a new backpack at the time because the one I had been bringing my computer to school with was way too big. So it felt nice to receive. I recognize, though, that companies often don't do these giftings entirely with the goodness of their heart in mind. Companies are interested in marketing their brands and their jobs to maintain a foot in the industries they are in. So I recognize that while it was a nice gesture, it was also promotion for the company, because their logo is embellished on the front of the bag.

GOLDEN CIRCLE	
	WHY: To fill a gap in the market for affordable bags that still look professional and credible. HOW: By using cheaper materials, but in a nice design with some tech in it to add value.

WHAT: A grey two-tone laptop backpack with USB and headphone ports, for consumers to obtain without breaking the bank, and for companies to have something they can buy and brand with their logos.

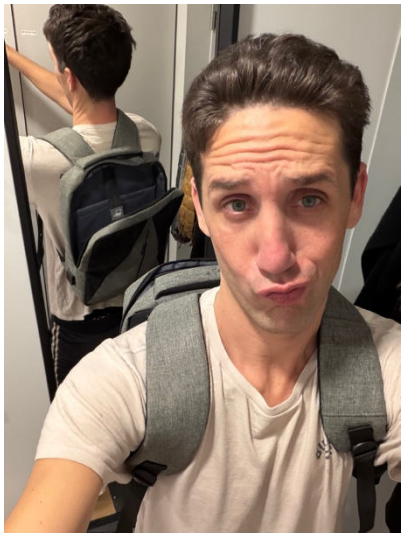


Market & Economic Context

The market for laptop bags is highly saturated, especially for bags with USB ports and headphone jacks. When I was doing my search to try and find a grey and black laptop bag with a headphone jack and a USB port on the internet, I found so many options it was overwhelming. I could not find the original product. I have found, though, that the top competitors in this market are XD Design (Bobby anti-theft series), Samsonite urban lines, and Targus. This market consists of budget utility bags, mid-range professional bags, and premium lifestyle bags. This bag I would consider mid-range.

User Context

This product is made for students (like me) and tech startup workers in metropolitan areas. It is designed for people that do not commute a long distance, but that distance may be heavily congested with people, like the subway or metro in a crowded city. It is made for users who have an interest in having a battery port for their phone inside their bag while commuting to work or school, without it being exposed to the public. I would say this bag is made for people who can't afford the high-end bags but still want something that looks nice. It is affordable. It is also manufactured for companies that want branding materials on a budget. I would say the design is very chic; however, it is not made with quality materials. It is made for short commutes because it does not have the capacity to fit a lot of items inside. People interested in travelling longer distances are likely to want to bring more items.



Physical Context

The bag is used when moving from point A to point B, walking between class and work, and travelling to the library. It must survive outdoor conditions: rain, crowded public transport, and overhead bins. It is used daily, stored overnight, and carried for hours at a time. It is also designed to hold possibly heavier laptops and gaming laptops, because it has padded straps for comfort and polyester fabric. Also, the zippers are embedded in a way that kind of hides them, which I believe adds to the protection from theft, along with the USB port and the headphone jack on the inside, so that one could leave their devices inside without taking them out, making it hard for thieves to find the zipper and rob the user.

Technological Context

The USB port and the headphone jack would not have been placed in the bag if it weren't for the rise in popularity of the portable power bank, portable streaming devices, and the ability to bring music along with us. This trend has risen and without this technology their would be no USB port or headphone jack.

2. Company & Product Positioning

How the Company Positions Itself

Xahau is a blockchain and crypto company, not a bag company or a fashion brand. They build technology infrastructure, and they use products like this bag as a way to get their name out and build a community of people who are interested in blockchain. Their strategy is to attract people, build relationships, and stay visible. They do not sell physical products; giving away a branded bag to scholarship recipients is part of promoting themselves and building their brand awareness.

The manufacturer positions themselves as someone available to companies such as Xahau for products that they can purchase to help with branding, and also to people who want to buy nice-looking products without breaking the bank.

How This Product Is Positioned

This bag sits in the middle of the market — it is not a cheap bag and it is not a luxury bag. It is positioned as a professional, useful, everyday product that looks good without costing too much. The bag is positioned to look more expensive than it is, which is part of why the aesthetics and the construction don't fully match up.

Category	Urban tech laptop commuter backpack
Price tier	Mid-range — looks premium, made affordable
Target user	Students and young tech professionals in cities
Brand role	Daily-use branding tool and scholarship reward
Positioning	Affordable bag that looks professional and chic
Key competitors	XD Design Bobby, Samsonite urban lines, Targus

3. Product Typology

What typology does this product belong to?

This bag belongs to the typology of urban commuter laptop backpacks. These are bags designed for people who are commuting to work or school daily and bring their laptops with them. The ideal product in this category looks clean and professional, fits a laptop safely, has some anti-theft features, and is comfortable enough to wear for a full commute. It is also suited for someone who can't afford a high-end bag or doesn't want to spend the money on that.

Baseline feature

- A padded laptop compartment that fits at least a 15" laptop
- Multiple compartments for accessories and personal items
- Padded shoulder straps provide comfort for heavier laptops.

- A structured form that holds its shape when loaded
- A neutral colour that works in professional setting

Differentiators

- Anti-theft features like hidden or embedded zippers that are hard to find from the outside, and an internal USP and headphone port that allow users to not keep items outside the bag.
- A design that looks more expensive than it is
- Enough internal space to carry a full day's worth of items comfortably

4. Design Elements Analysis

Why the product exists

Layer 1 — Aesthetics

Colour, shape, material, appearance, attitude — what the object communicates in the first 0.1 seconds.



Colour

I believe the grey and the black are chosen to make the item look more professional, grey and black are seen more as neutral colors. Also using two black triangles and sharp line for the zippers add a chicness that makes the design thought out, and this sort of thought behind design implies luxury.

Form & Contour

There is something about the rectangular shape of the whole product that doesn't draw attention making it neutral, the two black triangles draw you in and give a more professional appeal. The fabric looks expensive even though it isn't and the zipper going straight up and down the bag instead of right to left make the item unique and I think in this sense uniqueness implies luxury.

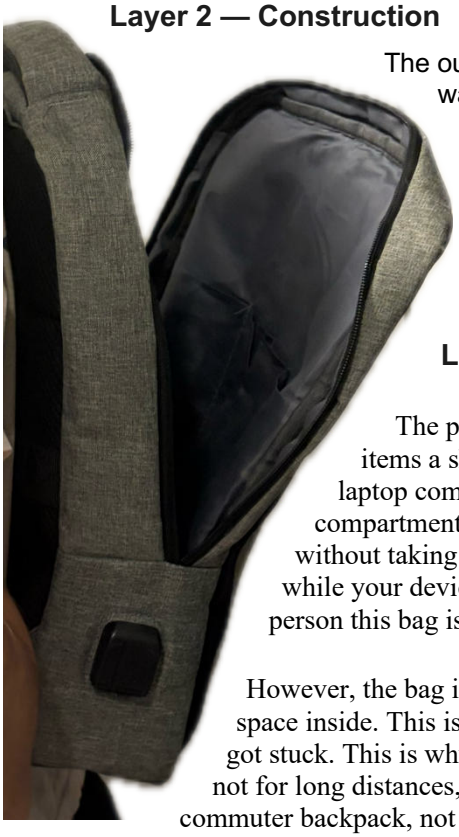
Texture & Finish

The front of the bag looks like a textured grey fabric that looks soft and rough at the same time, the inside has a padding around the bag container giving the appeal of safety and protection.The fabric looks expensive even though it isn't and the zipper going straight up and down the bag instead of right to left make the item unique and I think in this sense uniqueness implies luxury.

Attitude

The attitude is professional, hip, chic, and stylish.

Layer 2 — Construction



The outer shell is made from a polyester fabric. It is lightweight and looks water-resistant, but it is not heavy-duty material. The stitching holds together well enough for light use, but it's not made for heavy-duty usage. My zipper ripped off after about a year of use, which tells you something about the quality of the hardware.

Layer 3 — Performance

The primary function of this bag is to carry a laptop and a small amount of items a short distance through a city commute. It does this well for light use. The laptop compartment is padded and keeps the laptop protected. The multiple compartments keep things organised. The USB port lets you charge your phone without taking it out of the bag, and the headphone jack means you can listen to music while your device stays inside. These are genuinely useful features for the kind of person this bag is made for.

However, the bag is not made for long trips and heavy loads. It does not have a lot of space inside. This is partially why the zipper broke — I was trying to put a lot inside and it got stuck. This is why the bag performs well for short distances with not a lot of items. But not for long distances, because long distances one usually brings more things. This is a light commuter backpack, not a travel bag.

Layer 4

When I first received this bag I genuinely thought it was a nice, expensive product. My first My impression was that it was refined and expensive. But after having it for about a year, the zipper broke pretty easily, making me realize that it was not the high-quality bag I believed it to be when I got it as a gift for my scholarship.

Affordances

The top handle affords picking the bag up quickly without putting the straps on. This is useful when you are moving fast between locations. The padded straps afford comfort with heavier weights and longer time periods. The USB port affords phone charging from inside the bag. The headphone jack inside affords your devices to be on the inside, protecting them from theft. The multiple zipped compartments afford organized storage of different item types. The embedded zipper affords a level of theft protection that a regular zipper does not.

Signifiers

The zipper straps signify pull here. The handle on top signifies pick it up here. The black padding material on the bottom signifies this is the bottom. The strap inside the bag's laptop compartment has a picture of a

laptop, signifying this is where you put the laptop. The USB port affords phone charging from inside the bag. The headphone jack inside affords your devices to be on the inside, protecting them from theft. The multiple zipped compartments signify multiple places for storage.



Discoverability

The entire bag is easy to figure out without any instructions. All the zippers are obvious. The shoulder straps are obvious. The top handle is obvious. The USB and headphone port is in a standard position on the strap and is easy to find once you know it is there. I would say the discoverability is on point.

Layer 5 — Meaning

This bag means a lot to me because I won it as an award with a scholarship that I received in Spring 2025. I didn't think I would receive the scholarship, so it really boosted my confidence receiving this. And it was a significant amount of money and I genuinely was so broke at the time and couldn't afford a new bag so I was so happy to receive this.

5. Hierarchy of Design Elements



Layer	Element	Design Intent & Meaning
Meaning	Scholarship context	I would say this is number one for me because I didn't care if it was cheap because it was something I won.
Construction	Fabric texture contrast	I think the contrast in fabrics sticks out to me the most first aside from it's meaning.
Aesthetics	Triangular front panel geometry	The one moment of visual personality. It gives the bag a recognizable silhouette and elevates it above a generic rectangle — without breaking the overall tone of restraint.
Performance	Structured rectangular form	Enables the laptop-carrying promise. Without it the silhouette collapses. Also communicates discipline and control — a formal, upright object.
Aesthetics	Attitude: professional, plain, serious	The emotional impression the whole product creates. Not aggressive, not playful — quietly confident. It belongs everywhere.
Performance	Structured rectangular form	Enables the laptop-carrying promise. Without it the silhouette collapses. Also communicates discipline and control — a formal, upright object.
Meaning	Two-tone grey/black palette	The most immediately readable signal. Before the bag is touched or opened, it has already communicated: neutral, serious, professional. This single choice carries most of the brand message.
Construction	Padded straps + multiple compartments	Baseline competence. Expected in this typology — they qualify the product but do not differentiate it. Important, but not the story.

6. The Product Story

The story of this bag starts with the need for students and young professionals to safely carry their laptops through busy cities to work or to school. They may be transporting in a crowded subway and want to listen to music on the way without the risk of their phone being snatched by a thief, so they needed a bag that they can put their items safely inside and just attach the headphones from the outside. At the same time, they cannot afford to spend a lot of money on a bag. The manufacturer of this bag identified that gap and created this product to fulfill that. A chic looking tech bag page for a decent price.

Xahau found this bag and saw an opportunity. They needed a way to reward their scholarship recipients with something useful, while also getting their name out into the world. A branded backpack that someone carries every day to school or work is a subtle way to do that. It is a gift and an advertisement at the same time.

For me personally, this bag arrived at exactly the right moment. I had just won the InFTF scholarship, which I genuinely did not expect to win. I was broke, I needed a new bag, and then this arrived with my name on the scholarship. I did not care what brand it was or how it was made — it meant something to me because of the context it arrived in.

Over time though, the design started to tell a different story. The zipper broke. I realized the fabric was cheaper than it looked. I started to see the gap between what the bag promised and what it actually was. And that gap is the real design story. The manufacturer made something that looks like it is worth more than it costs. That is the entire strategy — and it works, right up until the moment it breaks because of the poor quality of materials.

CONCLUSION

This bag succeeds at the one thing it was designed to do: look more expensive than it actually is. For a corporate gifting context, that is enough. Xahau got their logo onto something a scholarship recipient carries in public every day, and the recipient got something that felt like a real reward. The design — the grey palette, the triangular panel, the tech ports — all works together to create an impression of quality that the construction does not fully back up. That is the honest story of this product. It is built for appearance, and for a while, the appearance is convincing.



